who had won seats and may reflect pressure from the NLD and its Rakhine allies to remove any political representation for the Rohingyas. One way to do this and thus boost the other parties' relative share of the seats in the national parliament was to claim that those Rohingyas who had stood for parliament must have used fake identities.

This is important as it illustrates how prejudice against the Rohingyas has evolved and been stoked up by political elites for their own political expedients. Up to 1974, while facing many of the problems that all minority groups faced under military rule, the Rohingyas were still allowed some degree of participation in the limited political process allowed under the Burmese Road to Socialism, and some members of the Burmese Socialist Programme Party were ethnically Rohingya.[52] Even in 1990, they retained a degree of political involvement but this was to be steadily eroded in the period up to the partial restoration of democracy in 2010 and, as we will see, has been radically eroded since then.

After the 1990 elections, repression continued in the regions in the north and east of the country, and there were an estimated 120,000 refugees in camps on the Thai–Burmese border,[53] mainly fleeing ongoing violence between the regime and the hill tribes.[54] In addition, UNHCR (the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees) estimates there were some 450,000 internal refugees. This suggests that the level of violence in the border regions was less one of low-level insurgency and more that of a full-scale war as the regime sought to defeat those it saw as its enemies. Even since the move towards democracy in 2008, repression of the minorities in the mountainous border regions has continued, despite the armed conflicts having officially ended.[55]

Overall, by 1992 it appeared as if the military had faced down the political and social unrest in central Burma and regained full political control. However, the repression continued, as did economic hardship for almost all citizens of Burma.[56] An internal coup was attempted in 2001,[57] reflecting yet another factional dispute within the military. More serious for the regime were ongoing economic problems, and these created the next real challenge to the junta in a wave of open popular revolt in 2007, led by Buddhist monks, and, this time, widely televised in the West. The combination of a charismatic leader with Western links, Aung Sung Suu Kyi, and easier television access meant greater awareness in the West of